

AI white paper

How **AI** creates a **hybrid growth** model for dealerships



Introduction

Pinewood.AI enables retailers and OEMs to unlock value by showing them all data points, simply and in near real time. Making it easy to identify opportunities to improve performance. A unified management system and end-to-end visibility of data throughout the ownership journey.

Further enhanced with artificial intelligence to create a next generation expert system that automatically looks for actionable insights – sourcing, buying, selling, servicing and repairing. Designed by automotive industry professionals with deep experience of the business challenges that come with running a dealership. Our solutions have evolved in collaboration with both dealers and OEMs over more than 40 years.



Early in 2025 Pinewood.AI acquired Seez. Seez is an automotive technology company established in 2016 and focused on AI-powered solutions for car dealers and OEMs. With headquarters in Dubai and an office in Copenhagen, Seez delivers on customer engagement. Our solutions range from omnichannel retail platforms and predictive pricing models to advanced machine learning tools and AI-driven chat solutions. Operating across 16 countries, Seez empowers automotive businesses with data-driven insights and seamless digital experiences.

The Opportunity

Software has come a long way, evolving from on-premise systems, to apps and now to cloud platforms.

Each wave promised to make operations more efficient. But despite these advances, the fundamental approach remained unchanged: software was built to support human workflows, not to take over the execution of tasks.

In automotive retail, that meant dealership teams still carried the bulk of the operational load, manually entering data into CRMs, configuring workflows, generating orders. Software sped things up, but the impact was incremental, not transformative.



AI marks a clear turning point. For the first time, we're moving from software that assists with tasks to systems that can actually autonomously perform them. It's a fundamentally different value proposition, one where businesses aren't just making existing processes faster, but rethinking who (or what) does the work. Intelligent systems can now take on entire operational functions, allowing teams to shift their focus to higher-impact, strategic areas.

For automotive retail, this opens up new levels of scalability. Instead of spending time on routine processes, dealership teams can focus on what truly drives growth—customer engagement, brand experience, long-term planning. AI is driving us toward a future where software doesn't just enable the work, it takes charge of it. That's not a hype cycle. It's the start of real transformation.

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The Challenges



The key barriers to AI adoption mirror those seen with the introduction of any new technology: integration challenges, training existing staff, and a general hesitation to move quickly. Many companies feel there's no immediate need to adopt AI and prefer to wait until the technology matures further.

However, with AI, waiting might not be the best strategy. The more data AI can work with, the more powerful and accurate it becomes. And the best way to gather more data is simply through time and use. So, in fact, starting early has a distinct advantage. By adopting AI sooner, businesses can begin accumulating valuable data that helps refine the algorithms and drive better results. By hesitating, companies risk missing out on the competitive advantage that comes from leveraging AI from the outset.

While the pace of innovation is staggering, the barrier today isn't technical complexity, it's organizational readiness. Knowing how to use AI is no longer the challenge; knowing how to implement it effectively, train it on the right data, and embed it meaningfully into operations is where the real gap lies.

In the short term, legacy systems do present a challenge, as integration is key for effective data collection. However, as AI agents mature, this issue will gradually diminish. AI is becoming increasingly capable of operating independently. These agents will soon be able to interact with systems just like a human would, logging in, navigating, and extracting the necessary data without direct integration.

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Organizational Considerations

Company culture plays a pivotal role in AI adoption, especially in industries where change is often met with caution.

AI can trigger concerns around job security, but the real opportunity lies in reframing it: not as a threat, but as a tool that enhances human capabilities.

At Pinewood.AI we have direct experience of this through our Automotive Intelligence offerings. With features like automated customer interactions and personalized recommendations, we have observed the benefit of teams no longer having to spend time on repetitive tasks like responding to routine inquiries or sorting through inventory data. Instead, they were able to focus on high-value interactions, building relationships and closing sales.

The transition was successful because it was driven from the top. Senior management positioned AI as an enabler, not a replacement. That culture shift made all the difference: reducing resistance, boosting confidence, and fostering an environment open to innovation.

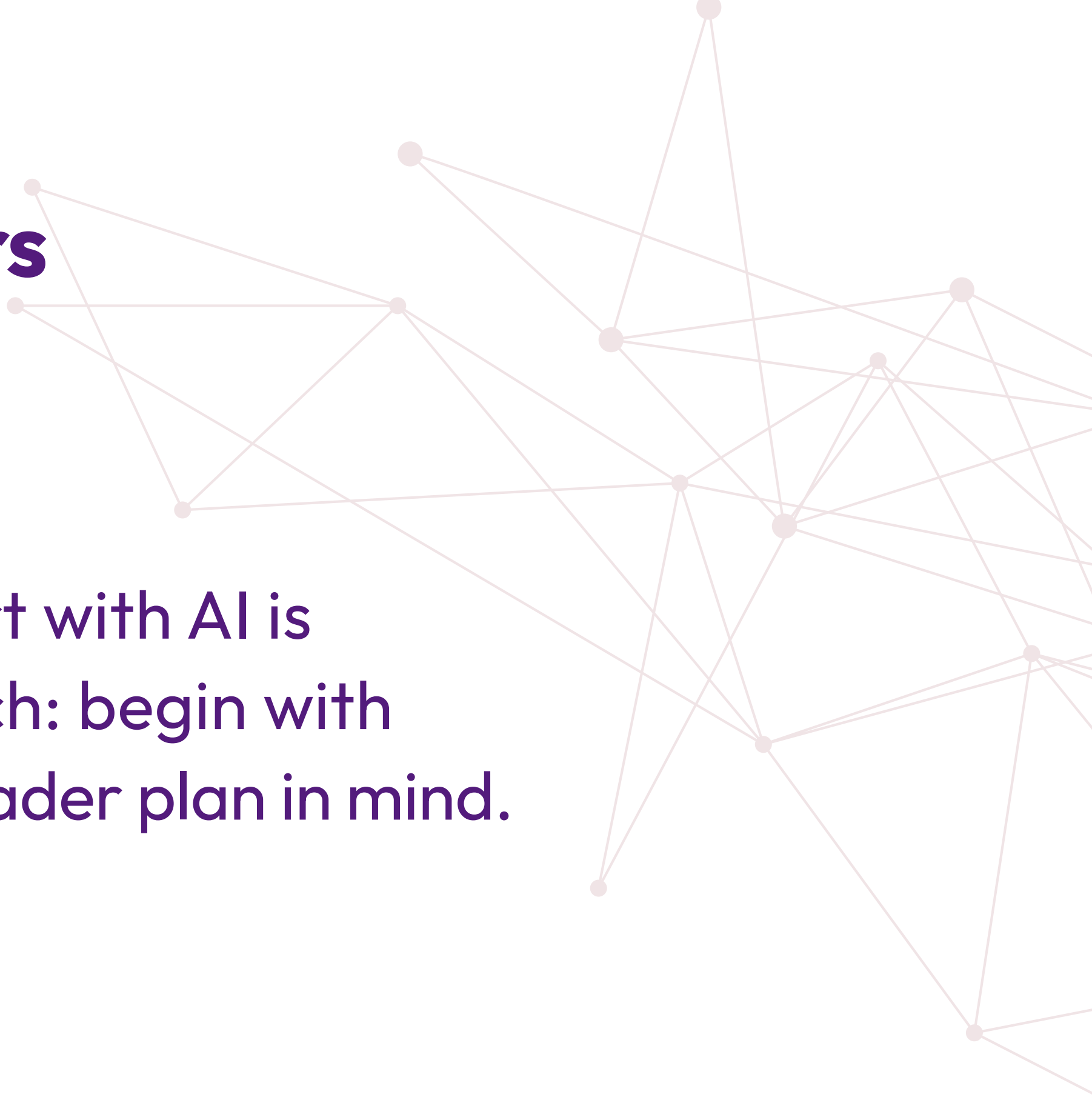
In our experience, AI adoption only sticks when it's championed by leadership. When done right, it empowers teams, enhances efficiency, and leads to a more scalable business.



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Bill Berman, CEO of
Pinewood Technologies Group PLC

Critical Success Factors



For most, the best way to start with AI is through a two-tiered approach: begin with small initiatives, but with a broader plan in mind.

In the short term, companies should identify one or two specific, low-risk use cases that clearly demonstrate value, like using AI chat to manage after-hours customer inquiries. These early wins help teams get comfortable with AI and build internal momentum without triggering fears around job displacement.

But those initial efforts should align with a larger strategic direction. Too often, we see companies scatter AI features across departments; the tools don't connect, don't scale, and ultimately don't deliver. It might feel like progress, but it's just execution without alignment.

The real transformation begins when AI is embedded into a company's data infrastructure and integrated systems. That's when organizations stop merely enhancing existing workflows and start using AI to design entirely new ways of working.

Every company—regardless of geography—sits on proprietary data that is highly valuable and often underutilized. This internal data is what sets businesses apart. While foundation models like ChatGPT are trained on public datasets, they don't have access to the specific, contextual, and often higher-quality proprietary data that exists within organizations.

That's where the real opportunity lies. Proprietary data enables companies to move beyond generic AI capabilities and build tools tailored to their operations, customers, and market.

How AI Unlocks Value

In broad terms there are three main ways AI can be deployed to unlock value. In each case the AI can work in conjunction with a human, performing the role of an expert support partner; or it can work autonomously, making decisions (within agreed parameters), interacting directly with customers and employees.

Expert Guide. AI agents can retrieve information almost instantly and with unprecedented accuracy. They can answer any question about an individual model, show comparisons with other models including ones from other manufacturers. They can discuss service appointments and match what they offer against the availability of individual technicians if specialist knowledge is required for that customer's vehicle. They can show finance teams multiple KPIs and identify potentially significant variables that might be affecting performance.

Efficient Automation. Using AI to automate tasks and workflows that involve a high degree of repetition and where there are scheduling rules in place for when something needs to happen. For example, requesting customer feedback and then prompting them if they do not respond the first time. Or setting up new employees on internal systems and scheduling onboarding when they start.

Autonomous Agents. Advances in AI training through Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) that combines LLM models with historic and real-time corporate data can create agents capable of delivering hyper-personalized customer experiences. If combined with Natural Language Processing (NLP) these agents can even interpret customer emotions and adjust their responses accordingly.

Unlocking Value on the Buying Journey

For any buying journey, not just automotive, we can think of two types of opportunity to engage a potential customer.

There is information that can help them with a rational decision e.g. deciding what they can afford, understanding the economics of buying an EV. Then there is inspiration that will create an immediate positive emotion, with the potential to sway their decision in your favour. That might be a sales or finance offer, or a great experience when they talk to a salesperson or visit a dealership.

The traditional problem for dealers is that their ability to leverage these opportunities have been limited to knowledge about the cars they sell and that they can only answer questions in the times when salespeople are available. An AI agent doesn't have these limitations. If a customer is looking at model X and says they're also considering model Y, then the AI agent can ask what they liked about model Y and say how model X compares on those criteria.

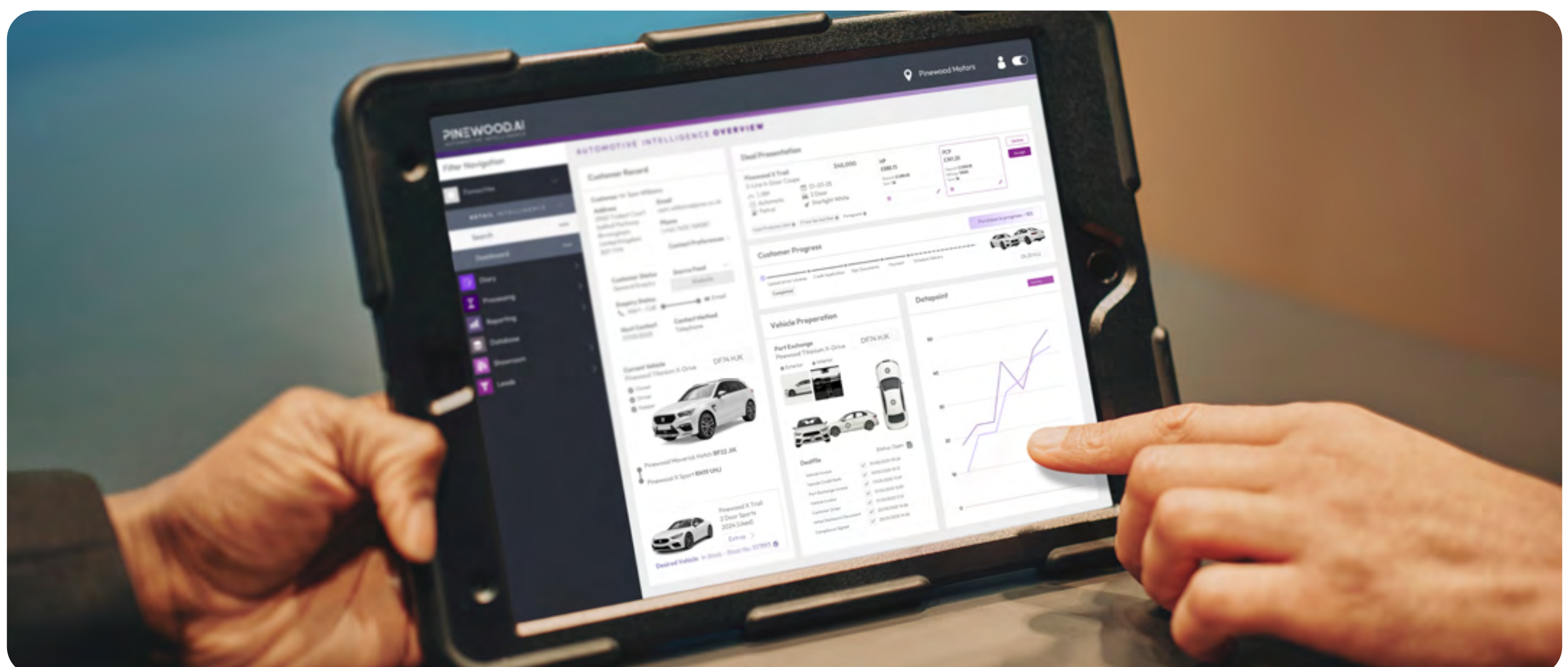
As with all major, high consideration purchases buyers can often take a long time to make up their minds.

Just because someone hasn't returned to the website in a couple of weeks, or didn't respond to the follow-up from a salesperson, doesn't mean they've lost interest or gone elsewhere.

The AI agent can play the long game at scale, regularly checking in with prospects, regardless of how many there are, whilst giving them every opportunity to say if they are no longer interested.

And AI agents that have received language training can adjust the tone and language of their conversations based on the tone and language that the customer uses.

“Technical questions that even the best salespeople would need to look up, such as emissions, length of vehicle or boot capacity can be answered instantly. 24/7/365.”



Unlocking Value on the Ownership Journey

Buyer expectations for the communications they receive once they've made a purchase have been fundamentally reshaped by ecommerce. They expect to be updated constantly about the status of their order, to know their delivery schedule in precise detail, and to be invited to share their experience.

With new vehicle buyers waiting weeks between purchase and delivery how good are dealerships at keeping customers excited in anticipation of receiving their vehicle, at managing their natural impatience at how long they think it's taking? There are also multiple opportunities to add value to the ownership experience, as well as generate incremental revenue beyond service and maintenance.

For example, most owners will never read the instruction manual and therefore miss out on ways they can improve their driving experience. And whilst most salespeople may offer cosmetic protection alongside vehicle purchase, how many more customers will be more responsive to this once they've scuffed their alloys the first couple of times?

Keeping in contact with customers and making those communications relevant and engaging is not easy, and most dealers are too busy selling vehicles to dedicate time and resource to this. AI has none of those limitations.

AI can be trained with the expertise to help customers get the most from their vehicles and their driving experience. It can then leverage the goodwill it creates by doing this to identify opportunities for additional sales to that household. This also helps maintain positive awareness of the dealership, so the customer is more likely to buy from the same dealer when they are ready to replace their vehicle.



Measuring the ROI

Measuring the ROI of AI depends on where you are in the journey.

Early on, it's about simple, quantifiable gains: how many hours did the AI bot save? How many off-hours support agents did it replace? How many new leads did it generate? These metrics help build confidence internally and justify the initial investment.

But over time, as AI begins to take on more complex tasks and complete them from start to finish without human involvement, the conversation shifts. ROI becomes tied directly to outcomes: actual business results delivered.

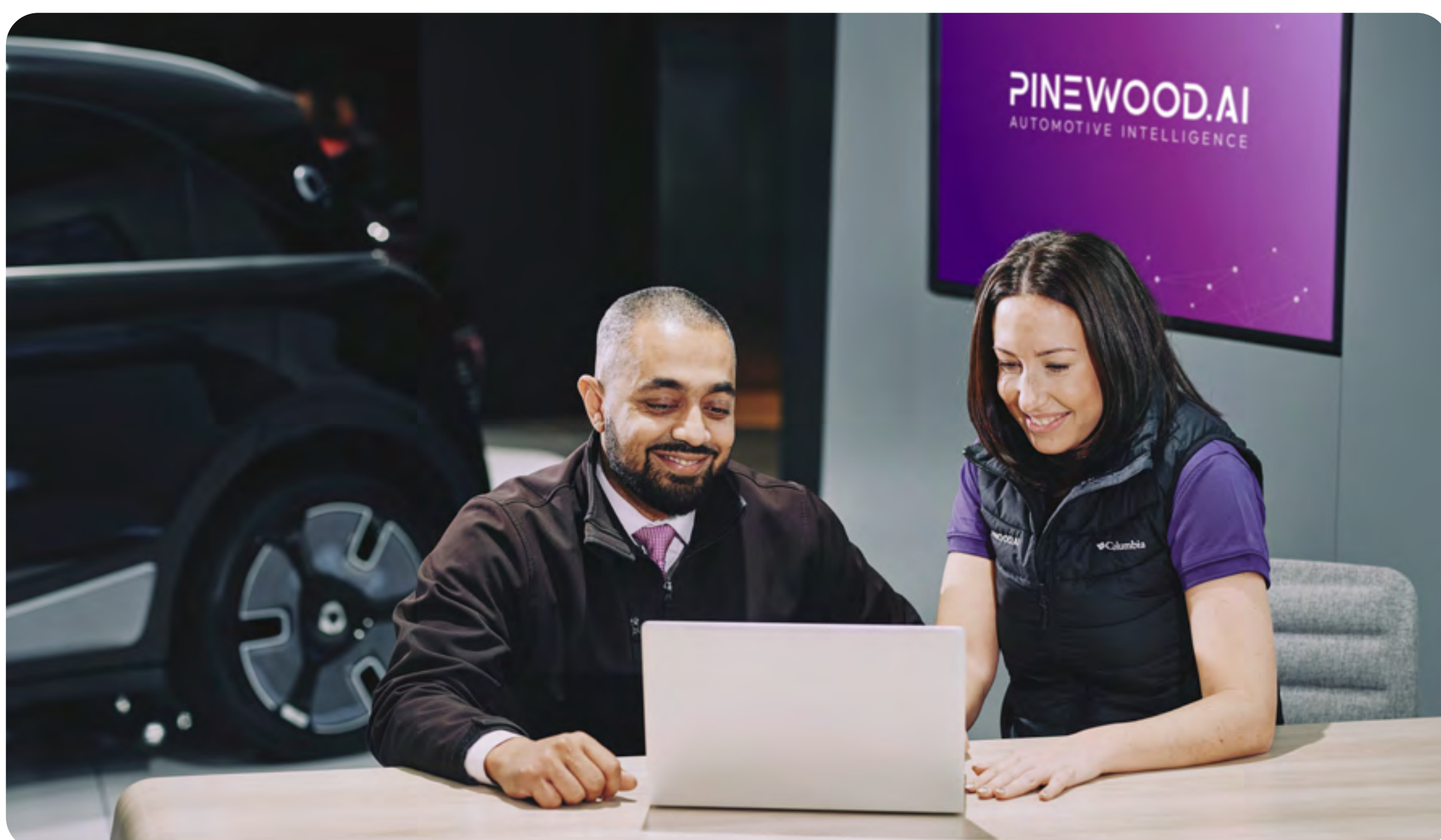


The future is Specialist and Hybrid

Predicting the future is always a risk. The evolution of AI and how its application can benefit businesses is at such an early stage and there will undoubtedly be many twists and turns. But we believe there are a couple of ways AI is used that will become key to how successful it is.

Right now, we still think of AI in generalist terms. We might distinguish between AI agents for sales, service/workshop and customer service, but that's about it. Is that the best way to plan your AI strategy?

We know that the quality of AI decision-making depends on the quality of data and there is no substitute for real-time data. In other words, as with humans, AI learns by experience. What is also the same as for us humans is that gaining real expertise happens faster when you focus on being a specialist than when you try to learn several different things at the same time.





That approach leads to building AI teams that combine complementary specialist skills. The difference with the equivalent human teams is their ability to work together effectively, and for the customer never to know they are dealing with a team. Set agents up to explicitly operate as a human team would. For example, to work as part of the sales team, why not train Sales agents, F&I agents, Compliance agents and even an Audience agent who shapes the overall response according to their understanding of differences between customers?

The other prediction we will make is that successful strategies will never frame things in terms of AI versus Human. There are clearly individual tasks that AI can perform more reliably, but humans need to be in the loop; to initiate what the AI does, to intervene when necessary and above all to input and build AI's understanding of context and nuance. In the same way we no longer think of digital dealerships or physical dealerships, the future is hybrid - one team with humans and AI working alongside each other.

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